subsequently reaching agreement with David Beckham on his personal contract. Manchester United confirms that in the event that all of the conditions are fulfilled then the offer would be acceptable.'

Was I in earthquake country? I couldn't believe what I was hearing. No word from the manager, no word from anybody at the club, after a dozen years at United. Just the plain, bare announcement dated June 10: we're selling him. Mr Laporta, with all due respect, wasn't even President of Barcelona yet but a deal had been done. It was like they couldn't wait to get rid of me. I just sat down on the floor where I was. I was angry all right. I didn't like the news, and how I'd found out about it, some time after the rest of the world, was humiliating. Tony and I talked about what to say and what to do. Later that day, he released a statement for me:

'David is very disappointed and surprised to learn of this statement and feels that he has been used as a political pawn in the Barcelona Presidential elections. David's advisors have no plans to meet Mr Laporta or his representatives.'

I know now that Manchester United regretted it coming out the way it had. They'd been under pressure, not just from the media but also from the club's stockbrokers. But that wasn't the point, as far as I was concerned. I'd just heard the truth, hadn't I? I wasn't just up for sale. I'd been carted as far as the checkout. Something shifted inside me. I'd been uncertain about my relationship with the Manchester United manager all season long. Now, for the first time, it was my relationship with the club that was slipping away. And that broke my heart. I had to start thinking seriously now about starting a career away from Old Trafford, after a lifetime of knowing that playing for United was all I'd ever wanted to do.

Barcelona are a great club: history, tradition, players, everything. I was honored they wanted me. Just as I felt honored when I heard about the two big Italian clubs who were interested in me as well. Deep down, though, as soon as I realized I might be leaving Old Trafford, there was only one club I wanted to join. A club as big as United and, over the years, even more successful. A team that included some of the best players on earth. From a soccer point of view, there was only one choice. It had to be Real Madrid.

This wasn't just a soccer decision, though. There were so many things to think about. This was something so huge in our lives—for me, Victoria and the boys—that, at first, I think we had trouble even knowing where to start thinking about it. For Victoria, with a career of her own, it was the first time a